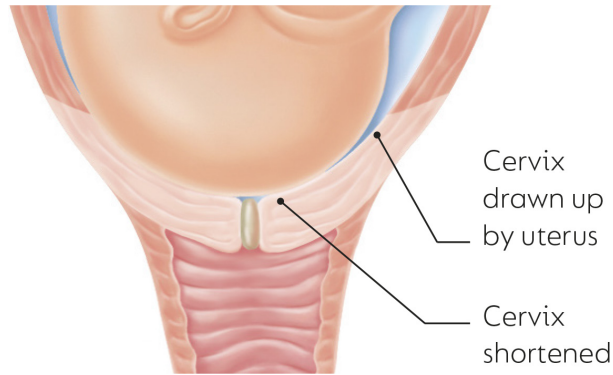
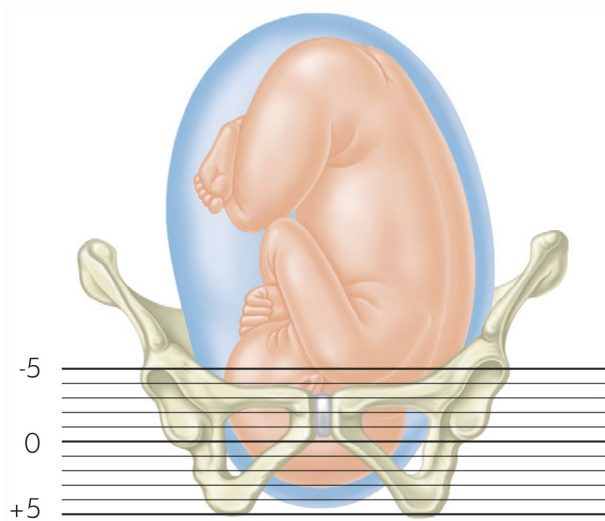




Once the cervix has softened, it starts to shorten. This process is referred to as effacement and needs to occur before the cervix can begin to dilate.

THE “STATION”

The “station” refers to the position of your baby’s head in relation to your pelvis. This is recorded as a number between -5 and $+5$. Zero station means the head is “engaged” and has entered the vaginal canal within the pelvic bones. A negative number (-5 to 0) means that the head isn’t engaged in the pelvis. A positive number (0 to $+4$) means that your baby’s head is moving down the pelvis and $+5$ means your baby is crowning (being born). Ideally, you should not push until the head is engaged in the pelvis, even if you’re fully dilated.



The position of the head in relation to the pelvis is marked on a scale of -5 to $+5$.

DILATION

Once your cervix is stretched and softened (see [Changes to the cervix](#)), it begins to open, or dilate, so that your baby can pass through into the vagina to be born. Regular contractions cause the cervix to dilate, and in first labors the cervix dilates at an average of 0.5 cm per hour; this rate is often faster for subsequent labors. You cannot push your baby out until you are fully dilated, which occurs at 10 cm.